



supply system was devastated, from warehouses and fuel depots to roads, railroads, and bridges. In October the air strikes on the North, codenamed Linebacker, were halted after a breakthrough in the peace talks. By then, the North Vietnamese had realised that they could not conduct a conventional war in the face of American air power.

### Christmas bombing

The finale of America's air war in Vietnam brought the B-52s center stage. They had been extensively used during the fighting in 1972, but in the second half of December that year, with peace talks stalled on the verge of agreement, they were unleashed in a major offensive against Hanoi and Haiphong. President Nixon's typically crude comment on the operation, dubbed Linebacker II, was that "the bastards have never been bombed like they're going to be bombed this time."

Between December 18 and December 29, over 14,800 tons of bombs were dropped on targets in and around the North Vietnamese cities. At the peak of the offensive 120 B-52s attacked in a single night, backed up by fighters, ground-attack aircraft, electronic-warfare aircraft, and helicopter combat-rescue teams. The goal was to destroy North Vietnam's military and industrial infrastructure, including airfields, missile sites, army barracks, power stations, and railroad yards. To achieve accurate bombing and minimize politically unacceptable civilian casualties, the B-52s had to stay on a level course on the approach to their targets, despite facing volleys of SA-2 missiles fired up to greet them. Inevitably there

## HIGH-ALTITUDE PRECISION BOMBING

**DURING THE FIGHTING** in 1972, "cells" of three B-52s were used to strike at North Vietnamese ground forces operating inside South Vietnam, dropping their bombs from 7 miles (11km) high, often through dense cloud cover. Although guiding a bomber to release its bombs on a point defined by map coordinates had been practiced since early in World War II, it still required remarkable skill from aircrews and ground controllers when a five-second delay in bomb release would translate into about a 1/2-mile (0.8-km) error in targeting. The ground controllers tracking the B-52s on radar worked in threes, checking and double-checking one another's work. The lead B-52 was counted down to bomb release by the voice of a ground controller on the

radio: "Five, four, three, two, one, hack." The radar navigators in the other two planes hit their bomb switches a precise number of seconds later. The remoteness of the aircrew from the effects of their actions was total. Bomb release was felt as a slight shuddering of the aircraft and seen as a series of lights flicking off as each of perhaps 66 bombs fell away. The bombs hit the ground a minute later, by which time the B-52s had turned for home. The pilot might just glimpse flashes lighting up the clouds below. That was all.

### BLACK HOLE

*The radar navigator in a B-52 was the airman responsible for dropping the bombs. His position was on the lower deck, in the windowless "black hole" beneath the pilot and copilot.*

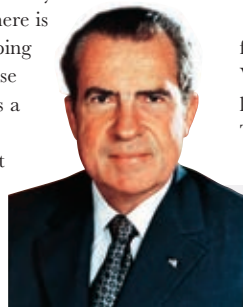


were losses – 15 B-52s were shot down – and equally inevitably there were bombs that missed their target, including one that struck a hospital. But on the whole Linebacker II achieved its objectives, wreaking destruction on a huge scale.

The Christmas bombing offensive was rapidly followed by an agreement that allowed the final withdrawal of American military forces from Vietnam. But there is little evidence that the bombing forced the North Vietnamese into any concessions. It was a display of strength that alleviated America's pain at having failed to win the war and was meant to warn the communists

what might happen if they broke the peace agreement. In reality, America's will to engage militarily in Vietnam had gone. When the North Vietnamese took over the South in 1975, the United States did nothing. The last use of American aircraft in Vietnam was to fly people out from the roof of the US embassy in Saigon as communist tanks entered the city.

Use of air power on an astonishing scale had failed to decisively influence the course of the Vietnam War, and had in fact become a political liability as the main target for critics of the war. Twenty years earlier, air power had been



### LAST HELICOPTER OUT

*President Nixon (above) engineered the final withdrawal of American forces from South Vietnam in January 1973. The United States was at the time committed to resume military action if the North Vietnamese broke the peace agreement, but the will to support South Vietnam soon faded. In May 1975, as the communist forces occupied Saigon, people struggled for a chance to escape in helicopters that would fly them to US carriers offshore (right).*

